COUNTRY REPORTS: ZAMBIA

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Status report

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Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

Opening the Fourteenth National Assembly on 9 October 2026, President Hakainde Hichilema set out a five-year Grow Zambia agenda that includes accelerating digitalisation and the adoption of artificial intelligence, and named internet access across the country, the country's own data centres and trained people as what that requires. Public administration is one of only three of the sixteen sub-categories in which Zambia went backwards over 2014-2023 in the 2024 Ibrahim Index of African Governance, edging down 0.2 points to 58.4 out of 100 and 19th of 54 — the part of the state that has to deliver the digital plans. Within it, budgetary and financial management is the fifth most deteriorated indicator of all, down 18.1 points to 56.9 out of 100 and 24th of 54, and administrative capacity pulls apart: effective administration up 3.6 points to 55.4 while tax and revenue mobilisation fell 8.3 points to 41.5, 31st of 54. This sits inside a rising overall picture — 56.6 out of 100 for overall governance, 17th of 54 and 7.3 points above the African average of 49.3, with Zambia above the continental average on 72 of the index's 96 indicators.

The paper commitments are unusually complete. The National ICT Policy 2023, published with an implementation plan by the Ministry of Technology and Science, is the overarching instrument, covering broadband, cybersecurity, data centres, digital identification, digital payments, e-waste, spectrum, quality of service and universal access. Alongside it the ministry carries a National Digital Transformation Strategy spanning broadband, data protection, digital payments and the first, second and last mile of connectivity, while SMART Zambia Institute's National e-Government Plan 2023-2026, issued under the Electronic Government Act, carries a dedicated thematic area on standards and compliance with phased milestones.

Delivery ownership is settled at the top and thin below it. The GovTech Maturity Index records a dedicated digital government institution established, with machinery for coordinating government technology across ministries in place, and a current digital transformation strategy in force with supporting institutional measures, a second instrument in the same family still only planned or in draft (2025). The same index finds no data governance body and no data governance strategy for government. The National Artificial Intelligence Strategy 2024-2026 is published, placing AI coordination inside government with SMART Zambia Institute under a National AI Council (2024).

Legislation and regulation

Enforcement of the Cyber Crimes Act commenced in July 2026, the Ministry of Information and Media saying the Act "applies equally to every individual without exception", with public servants singled out for a duty to protect confidential information held in the course of their duties.

The 2025 legislation is a pair of separate instruments that are routinely conflated: the Cyber Security Act No. 3 of 2025, which builds the interception and agency architecture, and the Cyber Crimes Act No. 4 of 2025, which carries the offences, both gazetted on 15 April 2025.

Underneath them sits a stack assembled in 2021. The Data Protection Act No. 3 of 2021 regulates the collection, use, transmission and storage of personal data and establishes the Data Protection Commissioner; the Electronic Government Act No. 41 of 2021 mandates the digitalisation of public services and establishes the Electronic Government Division; electronic signatures and electronic transactions sit under the Electronic Communications and Transactions Act No. 4 of 2021, which makes ZICTA the national root certification authority and whose amendment Cabinet approved in principle in September 2025 and put to stakeholder consultation in September 2026. The World Bank's GovTech Maturity Index also records a right to information law in force and rates it effective (2025).

The holes are in the newer areas. There is no dedicated digital identity law, digital ID being governed instead by the National Registration Act, the Electronic Government Act and the Data Protection Act. The government began amending the e-government law in January 2026, through a Bill giving legal standing to electronic submissions and digital authentication so services can run end to end digitally. Nothing governs artificial intelligence: the Ministry of Technology and Science names a Startup Bill alongside the forthcoming AI strategy, neither with published text (July 2026).

The 2025 Acts are contested. The Law Association of Zambia said in April 2025 it would mount a legal challenge to them, and an opposition running mate campaigned in July 2026 on repealing both. Where civil society has reached for statute over an alleged election-period messaging campaign, it has reached wider than data protection, citing section 83 of the Electoral Process Act No. 35 of 2016 and the Anti-Corruption Act 2012.

Data protection

Zambia's Cyber Security Act No. 3 of 2025 obliges every service provider to keep an interception capability and to store call-related information and internet connection records, with the manner of that capability set by presidential statutory instrument. It also places the Zambia Cyber Security Agency in the Office of the President, under the President's general direction.

Interception itself is court-gated. A law enforcement officer applies ex parte to a High Court judge for an order effective for three months, renewable once; the one route without a prior order is an oral request to a provider where a court order would be too slow, with the officer before a judge within two days. The class of officials who may seek interception — police, anti-corruption, drug enforcement, intelligence and counter-terrorism — can be extended by presidential statutory instrument.

The Data Protection Act No. 3 of 2021 governs the collection, use, transmission and storage of personal data and establishes the Data Protection Commissioner, and obliges a controller to notify the Commissioner within twenty-four hours of a breach and affected data subjects as soon as practicable. The Office of the Data Protection Commissioner was declared fully operational in April 2025, with a registration deadline of 30 April for controllers and processors and statutory penalties for non-compliance, and now takes part in the digital identity programme (May 2026). The GovTech Maturity Index rates the law effective and the authority as in place, while finding that neither publishes anything about its work (2025).

That silence is being tested: civil-society organisations asked the Commissioner in July 2026 to examine the source of the contact list behind an alleged bulk-SMS campaign to social cash transfer beneficiaries, and ZICTA to trace the messaging channel. For the refugee register transfer, the project's own assessment names data privacy in capturing refugees' biometric data, where a breach of confidentiality could leave some at risk of exclusion (December 2024).

Digital freedom is Zambia's ninth most improved Ibrahim Index indicator, up 19.7 points over 2014-2023 to 76.4 out of 100 and 14th of 54 — a measure of online censorship, interference with online content and users' rights, whose 2023 data year precedes the 2025 Acts. The technology ministry's permanent secretary said the country is implementing a national child online protection strategy for 2025 to 2029.

Regional collaboration

Lusaka hosted a COMESA and World Bank regional AI workshop in July 2026, launched as a first step toward a COMESA Regional AI Strategy framed against policy fragmentation across the bloc — Zambia helping shape the regional framework while its own successor national strategy is still unpublished.

On identity the reach is real but provisional. Zambia is piloting cross-border mutual recognition of national IDs and ID verification with COMESA and neighbouring IDEA countries including Angola, the DRC and Malawi, and formal cross-border interoperability of the digital ID is not yet implemented (2025). The cooperation it has reached for is African rather than vendor-led: an identity memorandum of understanding with Ethiopia, drawing on the Fayda system, chosen because it is domestically developed.

Payments cross the border only at wholesale level. Zambia's cross-border payment connections run through the regional wholesale rails SADC-RTGS and the COMESA Regional Payment and Settlement System, with no instant retail cross-border link from the national instant payment system.

The wider integration measure is drifting the wrong way. Zambia, landlocked and a member of both COMESA and SADC, scores 47.8 out of 100 on the Ibrahim Index's regional integration measure, 26th of 54 and down 1.6 points over 2014-2023; that measure covers trade, movement and infrastructure integration, and carries no digital or data-flow component of its own.

Standards

Zambian officials pursuing the e-government law amendment name fragmented, vendor-locked systems as a governance, policy and legal alignment problem rather than a technical one (January 2026) — a diagnosis reached with mandatory standards already on the books. SMART Zambia Institute's Public Service ICT Data Interoperability Standards are mandatory for all ministries, provinces and spending agencies and carry an annual compliance audit schedule, and together with the Electronic Government Act they set the data management and governance requirements for government data.

The instruments beneath them are in place. The GovTech Maturity Index records a government interoperability framework and a data-exchange platform extensively used across government (2025) and an electronic government procurement system in use for online tendering and contract management. In payments the rules are published rather than internal: the Bank of Zambia is both system and technical operator of the interbank payment and settlement system under the publicly issued ZIPSS Rules 2024.

The identity programme is the clearest case of standards chosen deliberately. It is designed as a homegrown system built on open standards and existing investments, explicitly so that government can manage its infrastructure independently and reduce reliance on external vendors, with privacy, security and interoperability as stated priorities, and SMART Zambia is procuring an international system integrator for a MOSIP-based register while insisting the application layer be built by Zambians on open standards to avoid vendor lock-in (March 2026).

Service standards in telecoms are enforced by announcement rather than instrument. ZICTA said in February 2026 it would take visible action against mobile network operators over poor quality of service, and quarterly network-performance reports were announced in May 2026 as the accountability measure on operator quality.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

Deliberative and participatory governance is Zambia's fifth most improved Ibrahim Index indicator, up 32.7 points over 2014-2023 to 79.1 out of 100 and 3rd of 54; the measure assesses whether government consults affected groups and the public before deciding. Civil society space is the third most improved, up 34.0 points to 76.8 and 11th of 54. The expression measures did not move with them: media freedom stands at 56.7 out of 100, 22nd of 54 and up 1.3 points over the decade, and freedom of expression and belief at 71.6, 18th of 54 and down 1.1 points. All are expert-coded assessments with a 2023 data year, which precedes the 2025 cyber laws.

The channels exist and are partial. Zambia has a central citizen feedback and grievance-redress platform for public services, with five of the six mechanisms the GovTech Maturity Index tracks in place (2025), and a government e-participation platform that also carries citizens' petitions, though three of the five further participation mechanisms the index tracks are absent. The cyber bills show how far consultation reaches: deferred at Second Reading in December 2024 for talks with civil society, they returned to the House on 25 March 2025, the ministry saying 98% of the concerns raised had been resolved and civil society that many of its key recommendations were not adopted. Getting at the record is harder than being heard: a right to information law is in force and rated effective, while the disclosure and accessibility of public records are the weakest part of Zambia's Ibrahim Index accountability score and both fell over 2014-2023.

The election has narrowed the register of the debate. The Human Rights Commission raised the alarm over hate speech and online abuse ahead of the August 2026 vote, asking citizens to verify information before sharing it and political leaders to drop inflammatory language and unverified allegations. On 11 September 2026 the Lusaka Magistrates' Court convicted a vlogger under the Cyber Security and Cyber Crimes Act No. 2 of 2021 for passing to a WhatsApp group a screenshot making allegations about a presidential aide. The Zambia Cyber Security Agency spent July 2026 urging journalists to learn the cybersecurity laws before the election, presenting the legislation as protection for media houses against ransomware and disruption, and MISA Zambia launched its 2025 Digital Rights Report on 30 July 2026.

Finance

Financial sustainability

Zambia's 2026 budget carries a K1 billion World Bank grant for the Digital Zambia Acceleration Project inside the Smart Zambia Institute's standards and regulation line, where the 2025 budget footnoted no donor money against any digital line; the project's grant window runs to 2030.

About 66 percent of the K2.93 billion appropriated on the digital lines for 2026 is the state's own money, the rest being that grant.

The lines that keep systems running are on the state's own votes: the 2026 budget gives the institute K119.7 million for ICT infrastructure and K102.7 million for ICT security, and the finance ministry K40.8 million for SAP licences, the same sum as in 2025. Money voted is not all spent. In 2025 the institute's standards and regulation line spent K152.3 million of K288.0 million authorised, and the technology ministry's ICT infrastructure line K107.7 million of K204.1 million, while ICT security spent K114.3 million of K115.8 million.

Own-source financing of connectivity is in law. Regulations of 2012 require licensees to pay into the Universal Access Fund at a rate not exceeding 1.5 percent of gross annual turnover, capped at half their annual operating fees and payable in advance, with the Fund account run by ZICTA.

The state's infrastructure company earns its keep commercially. INFRATEL, wholly owned by the government through the Industrial Development Corporation, owns three Tier III data centres and more than 1,200 towers and is funded from tower services, data-centre revenue and investments; it leases shared tower sites to MTN under a five-year contract from January 2024 at a monthly fee per site, and was owed K362.9 million by customers at the end of 2024. The finance minister said in May 2026 that hundreds of new towers were going up through public-private partnerships, with no partnership terms published.

MoUs and other agreements

The Zambia Revenue Authority signed both a memorandum of understanding and a non-disclosure agreement with the International Centre for Tax and Development in July 2026, covering research, capacity building and innovation for data-driven tax administration and domestic resource mobilisation. The non-disclosure agreement is the binding half of it, and no value or duration is attached to either.

Huawei signed twice within a month. A memorandum of understanding with the government and the SMART Zambia Institute in May 2026 covers a National AI Data Centre, and a "sovereign AI" memorandum at the June 2026 Zambia Mobile Congress covers AI infrastructure, a sovereign cloud and a co-invested national data centre keeping critical data in the country. Both are memoranda rather than contracts, with no published value, co-investment split or delivery date.

The identity and payments work runs on the same kind of paper. Zambia has an identity memorandum with Ethiopia's National ID Program, drawing on a system chosen because it was built domestically, and a 2023 memorandum with the Centre for Digital Public Infrastructure at IIIT-Bangalore on the design of its DPI use cases. On payments, the government and the Payments Association of Zambia have agreed a compact to accelerate digital financial services and reduce cash dependency, with quarterly regulatory coordination between the Ministry of Technology and Science, the Bank of Zambia and ZICTA, and the fintech Zoyk has entered a partnership with Visa to bridge local payment rails to global networks for SADC cross-border trade. None of these is a procurement, and none of them commits either side to a sum.

New investments

Chinese policy banks are much the largest source of external digital finance: four commitments from China Eximbank and China Development Bank worth about US$1.02 billion, nearly four-fifths of a recorded total of about US$1.30 billion across nineteen commitments with a stated amount, starting between 2015 and 2026. IFC and MIGA follow with US$105 million between them, the World Bank with US$100 million and British International Investment with US$66 million (2015-2026). It is overwhelmingly debt — five loans or buyer's credits worth about US$1.09 billion against twelve grants worth about US$115 million — and connectivity takes about US$973 million, with US$211 million going to a single urban surveillance loan (2015-2026).

The largest single commitment dates from December 2017: a China Eximbank credit against a US$392 million Huawei contract to extend ZESCO's national fibre backbone, a deal a former ZESCO board chairman says he was pressed to proceed with. Chinese lending built the state's digital plant: a US$65.5 million China Eximbank concessional loan of March 2015 covered a Huawei contract in full for Phase I of Smart Zambia, delivering the three government data centres, in Lusaka and at Zamtel's Roma and Kitwe switches, and a US$302 million China Eximbank concessional loan for communication towers followed in August 2017. Older still: Lusaka's ZTE street-camera Safe City system went back out to bid in 2015 after the first tender collapsed over corruption claims.

Western money is smaller: the World Bank's Digital Zambia Acceleration Project was approved in 2025 with a window to 2030, its IDA grant committed rather than disbursing. IFC lent US$75 million to IHS Zambia in 2021 to refinance rather than build, British International Investment's US$66 million of equity in it was fully exited by March

2021, and MIGA's US$30 million guarantee insures a private-equity stake in Airtel Money's Zambian arm, not the wallet. Sida holds the grant end: SEK 25.1 million and SEK 16.9 million committed over 2020 to 2025 for financial inclusion and digital finance.

Domestic money is thin: K255 million was approved in May 2026 for digital infrastructure and network quality, rural areas first, while the Smart Zambia Institute asks private investors to fill the gap. The regional programme's report for January to June 2026 records a second market engagement for the digital acceleration project on 22 April 2026, covering 300 cell towers, 2,000 km of fibre and connectivity for 500 public institutions.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

ZICTA revoked the network and service licences of Beeline Telecoms, the fourth mobile network operator, licensed in 2021 and trading as ZedMobile since 2024, with effect from 14 September 2026, citing missed rollout, quality-of-service and fee obligations.

4G signal reached 91.2 percent of Zambians in 2023, and 23.5 million mobile connections were active in October 2025, equivalent to 106 percent of the population — a count of SIM cards rather than of people. In the same month 33.0 percent of Zambians used the internet, 7.29 million out of 22.1 million, leaving 14.8 million offline (October 2025), and the offline share is not falling. Price is part of the answer: a low-consumption mobile data and voice basket cost 3.5 percent of GNI per capita in 2022.

The same split runs through the governance indices. Zambia's mobile communications score rose 35.6 points over 2014-2023 to 80.1 out of 100, eleventh of 54 African states and the country's second most improved indicator of 96, while the measure combining internet use, computer access and affordability reached only 34.0, twenty-fifth of 54, on a gain less than half as large. Public perception of infrastructure moved the other way entirely, down 18.7 points to 41.3 out of 100 (2023), against an 11.0-point administrative gain that lifted the infrastructure sub-category to 42.8.

Government's own network started from almost nothing: 263 of 15,600 targeted government sites were on the Government Wide Area Network in December 2022. Completion and service are not the same milestone — twelve Western Province sites were reported complete in February 2025 while SMART Zambia's provincial ICT officer said the network could not be used until ZAMTEL finished the last-mile links — but by July 2026 every local authority and post office in North-Western Province had been connected over fibre, reaching schools and health facilities. GovLink, a government-owned private 4G network for public institutions, launched on 15 July 2026 with healthcare as its flagship use.

Domestic traffic has one place to meet: LSK-IX in Lusaka, twelve peers over twelve connections and 76G of capacity, ten of the peers open (August 2024). Airtel Zambia is buying about 1,300 km of fibre from its related company Airtel Telesonic Zambia for K324.9 million (September 2026).

Data Storage

Section 70(1) of the Data Protection Act No. 3 of 2021 requires controllers and processors to store and process personal and sensitive personal data on servers or in data centres located in the country, subject to limited exceptions. There is no direct cloud on-ramp for AWS, Azure or Google Cloud: Johannesburg is the nearest hyperscale hub, and those services are reached remotely at latency above 100 milliseconds (September 2025). The

commercial market is small and telco-dominated, limited to Tier II facilities such as Paratus's carrier-neutral site and the state-linked National Data Centre operated by Infratel, with the first more advanced entrant, Africa Data Centres, not expected before 2026-27.

The state's own estate is better provided for on paper than in service. Government data centres run at Tier I to Tier III, with a Tier III facility targeted at the Integrated Command and Control Centre site, and cloud computing infrastructure is a pillar of the national digital transformation strategy. The government cloud itself remains a strategy rather than a running platform (2025). All of it sits on a grid on which drought left towns without power for up to 72 hours at a stretch (October 2024).

What is being built next is being built with a single vendor. Zambia, the SMART Zambia Institute and Huawei signed a memorandum of understanding in May 2026 for a National AI Data Centre, followed by a sovereign-AI memorandum at the 2026 Zambia Mobile Congress covering AI infrastructure, a sovereign cloud and a co-invested national data centre keeping critical data in-country. It is the same vendor whose 2015 contract built the national data centre in Lusaka and the two backup facilities behind it.

Energy

INFRATEL, the tower company, invested US$5 million in power resilience at mobile sites, deploying high-powered thermal batteries and upgrading solar plant (August 2026). A severe El Niño drought left one of the six turbines at Kariba running and 7 percent of its 1,080 MW generated, towns going up to 72 hours without power, and the energy minister promising at least three hours a day once the country's only coal plant returned to full output (October 2024). Telecommunications felt it first: with load-shedding at 12 hours a day in June 2024, the main tower company reported generator run-time and fuel spending rising, and was moving its towers onto solar, hybrid power and battery banks. The exposure is structural rather than accidental: renewables, overwhelmingly hydropower, account for close to 90 percent of Zambia's electricity generation (July 2025).

Reach is the other constraint. Electricity access reached 51.1 percent of the population in 2023, up from 47.8 percent in 2022 and 46.7 percent in 2021, and the 2023 National Energy Access Survey records 80.3 percent in urban areas against 34.0 percent in rural areas, a gap of roughly 46 percentage points, with the grid dominant and solar the main alternative. Access to energy is the second worst-scoring of Zambia's 96 IIAG indicators at 26.7 out of 100, 35th of 54, despite a 7.0-point gain over 2014-2023. Against that, off-grid electrification is an established policy line, with results-based financing for off-grid solar and mini-grids under the Beyond the Grid Fund, an Off-Grid Energy Taskforce and a mini-grid regulatory framework.

Where the digital estate has spread, power has gone with it rather than after it. The government's electronic health record is concentrated in facilities where solar power and internet connectivity have been secured; the Ministry of Health, the Smart Zambia Institute and UNDP agreed in October 2025 to extend solar power and connectivity together to rural and peri-urban health facilities that have neither; the Smart Zambia Institute has a partnership with ZESCO to extend digital access to schools, health facilities and public administrations; and it reported in March 2026 that solar power had been provided to every council so they can operate around the clock.

Technical Capacity

Zambia's government systems are bought rather than built: of the eight whose software type is on record in 2025, six run commercial off-the-shelf products and only two — tax management, and the public investment management system under implementation — are custom.

That extends to the machinery of the civil service itself: the human resource management information system and the payroll system are both commercial off-the-shelf products, with most HR services online or digitised (2025). The identity platform is where the state has tried to reverse the pattern. SMART Zambia Institute e-government developers have taken MOSIP training so the platform can be run in-country, though development and capacity building still depend substantially on external partners (2025), and the institute said in March 2026 that the digital identity system would be developed by Zambians, with an international partner used only for technical support.

The institutional scaffolding is in place. A dedicated digital government institution is established, with machinery for coordinating government technology across ministries, alongside a public sector innovation institution whose focus areas are digital skills and public service innovation (2025). A digital skills strategy and a training programme for public servants cover basic digital skills and data literacy, including fee-based training, and the Smart Zambia Institute launched a decentralised version of that training for government staff in December 2025.

The tertiary pipeline is long-standing rather than new: the University of Zambia's Department of Computing and Informatics dates from September 1998 and admitted its first computer science degree students in August 2000.

Cybersecurity

Zambia scored 92.58 out of 100 in the ITU's Global Cybersecurity Index 2024, up from 68.88 in 2020, which places it in the second of the index's five tiers, advancing, with Benin, South Africa and Togo, behind the five African states rated role-modelling. A National Cyber Security Policy was approved in January 2021, and the Cyber Crimes Act No. 4 of 2025 was signed by President Hakainde Hichilema on 8 April 2025 and gazetted a week later, criminalising unauthorised access, computer fraud, malware and the knowing spread of false information that damages another person's reputation. Its section 10 makes it an offence to record a private conversation without notifying the parties to it, whether or not the recorder is one of them. Its investigatory powers are judicially gated throughout Part III, from search and seizure on a warrant to an ex-parte judicial order for real-time traffic-data collection.

The companion Cyber Security Act No. 3 of 2025 is a separate instrument and places the Zambia Cyber Security Agency in the Office of the President, administering the Act under the President's general direction. Its remit has since widened: the Ministry of Home Affairs has placed AI-enabled human trafficking and online scams inside its response (July 2026).

The laws drew an unusual objection. The US Embassy in Lusaka warned American citizens in April 2025 that the new cyber law "requires the interception and surveillance of all electronic communications"; Home Affairs Minister Jack Mwiimbu rejected the characterisation, saying the laws are meant to protect citizens. Enforcement of the Cyber Crimes Act commenced on 18 July 2026, weeks before a general election, and the agency urged journalists that same month to learn the laws, presenting them as protection for media houses against ransomware and disruption.

Operational defence is thinner than the statute book. ZICTA deactivated 43,500 SIM cards linked to mobile money fraud between January and June 2026, securing K19.8 million, work that reaches it through consumers reporting scammers on the *707# short code under its consumer-protection mandate in the ICT Act. A centralised national Security Operations Centre, and vulnerability assessment tools for the national Cybersecurity Incident Response Team, are provided for under the Digital Zambia Acceleration Project (2025).

DPI

Data Exchange

Zambia's Government Service Bus carried 290 deployed services (July 2024), and the World Bank's maturity index records the country as having both a government interoperability framework and a data-exchange platform in extensive use (2025).

What crosses it is more than a catalogue of endpoints. The land administration system runs on the bus and checks National Registration Cards against the Ministry of Home Affairs and retrieves company profiles from the company register while a land transaction is in progress (2023). The customs administration and the central financial management system exchange data with other government systems through the bus and through dedicated interfaces (2025). The Revenue Authority agreed in 2022 to interface its TaxOnline platform directly with the bus, and company, tax and pension registration data have been shared across three agencies through the One Stop Shop Integrated System since around 2015, longer than the bus itself. Civil registration is being wired in now: birth and death notifications are being automated end to end through the registration system's API manager so that population records update in real time (December 2025). Inside health, the patient record has exchanged laboratory orders and results with the DISA laboratory information system since June 2024.

The reach stops well short of the whole state. Government's own electronic government plan calls the platform landscape fragmented, interoperability partial and ICT systems still built in silos (2023); the identity estate remains spread across agencies collecting their own fingerprints, facial images and iris scans for their own services, with its integration a project commitment rather than a finished one (2025); and the electoral register is not connected to the exchange at all (June 2025). The data interoperability standards are mandatory for every ministry, province and spending agency (2024), and officials pushing the amendment of the Electronic Government Act name fragmented, vendor-locked systems as a governance and legal problem rather than a technical one (January 2026).

Digital Identity and CRVS

The system carrying Zambia's digital identity had been deployed in 11 of the country's 116 districts (2026), with around 1.3 million people enrolled on it and more than 500,000 births and deaths recorded (December 2025).

The funded ambition is far more modest than the announced one. The World Bank operation carrying the work targets 4 million people holding a digitally verifiable identity by October 2030, against a baseline of 1.5 million in December 2022, while the implementing institute continues to maintain that digital identity cards will issue by the end of 2026 (July 2026) and the registrar general puts population-scale coverage at the end of 2027 (June 2025). Responsibility is split between the registration department, which issues the credential, and the institute, which owns the system.

What the state actually runs on is still the paper card. Registration is mandatory from age 16 with no earlier enrolment pathway, the card is the legally recognised proof of identity, and the great majority of adults hold one (2024) against 15 percent of adults registered biometrically (September 2025).

There is no dedicated digital identity law: the credential rests on the National Registration Act, the Electronic Government Act and the Data Protection Act, and that registration Act is itself flagged as needing to be brought into line with digital identity standards (2024). Zambian civil society organisations report that government does not explain what the biometric data required for services is collected for, or how it is shared (October 2025).

Enrolment is free of charge and collects name, date of birth, address, gender, ten fingerprints and a photograph, expressly excluding ethnic and other sensitive data. The institute is procuring an international system integrator for a MOSIP-based system integrated with civil registration, while insisting the application layer be built by Zambians on

open standards (March 2026). Refugees are being enrolled into the citizens' register rather than a parallel one, with UNHCR's registration database transferring to the Ministry of Home Affairs under the same project (September 2024). Re-evaluation of the bids to deploy and integrate the identity and civil registration modules was complete and awaiting the lender's review at June 2026.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Mobile money reached 76.1 percent of adults in the Bank of Zambia's FinScope 2025 survey, up from 58.4 percent in 2020 — a payments rail running well ahead of the foundational identity system meant to underpin it (2025).

Retail money moves over the National Financial Switch, operated by the Zambia Electronic Clearing House under central bank oversight and live nationally for instant payments between banks, non-bank financial institutions and payment service providers (2023), with MTN Mobile Money, Airtel Money and Zamtel Kwacha integrated as members for person-to-person transfer. The switch now also carries wallet-to-bank, bank-to-wallet and merchant payments, with an industry QR project under way (July 2026). High-value settlement runs through the interbank system, where the Bank of Zambia is both system operator and technical operator, and cheques are being phased out (July 2026).

Governance of the switch seats the central bank and the commercial banks: non-bank payment providers have no seat on the clearing house board and put their views through an association instead (2023). Across borders the country is connected at wholesale level only, through the SADC and COMESA regional settlement systems, with no instant retail link out of the national scheme (2023). Payments to the state run through the interbank system, whose 2024 rules provide for the central bank to process Revenue Authority transactions and point to integration with the financial management system and the treasury single account, and that account is in use across ministries, departments and agencies, settling over both gross-settlement and fast payment rails (2025).

Identity has not been the constraint on access: the refugee certificate has counted as valid know-your-customer documentation for mobile money and SIM registration since 2017, which is how refugees in the settlements receive digital payments. Banking is the weaker channel — access to banking services scores 35.9 out of 100, and still ranks 11th of 54 African states (2023). Collections through the national services portal were put at about K9.8 billion since its 2019 launch, on the finance minister's account of 30 September 2026.

Registries

Birth registration stood at about 14 percent (2024), one of the lowest rates in Africa, against a government goal of half by 2026, while the registration department has digitised close to 81 percent of the legacy civil registration records (2024) — the paper backlog is being cleared faster than new events are captured. Civil registration is also the seventh most deteriorated indicator in Zambia's Ibrahim Index profile, down 12.5 points over 2014-2023 to 62.5 out of 100 (2023).

Land carries the largest hole. Of an estimated 1.2 million numbered properties, fewer than 450,000 hold registered title deeds (January 2026), a denominator that leaves out customary land entirely, and the cadastre is outdated and incomplete, with council valuation rolls behind it — Lusaka's was last completed in 2019 and covers 82,265 properties (2024). The land platform itself is fully digital, land applications running through the government service bus rather than over a counter (2024).

The business register is the most complete of them: online incorporation and a public company search, 9,163 new companies registered between January and May 2026, and a taxpayer identification number generated automatically once registration completes for companies formed since 2020, with the taxpayer register running on

TaxOnline for registration, filing and payment nationwide. The electoral roll is digital and inspectable by USSD and online, and 8.79 million voters were certified for the August 2026 elections, 53.1 percent of them women — but the roll is built on possession of the paper registration card and searched by its number.

Social protection has an operational system integrated in real time with a payment gateway connecting nine providers and banks (2023), and beneficiaries are checked against their registration card at the point of payment, which the system uses to find duplicate records across districts (2025); a unified National Social Registry was approved by Cabinet in April 2025 and is still in early implementation. What joins none of these together is an address: there is no national address register, the addressing project is still piloting street naming, no addressing policy has been approved and councils keep disjointed records (2023).

Sectoral management information systems

Health runs the widest sectoral deployment in Zambian government: SmartCare Pro, the national electronic health record, was deployed in more than 2,000 health facilities by July 2026 and is among the first systems moving onto the government's private 4G network, about 80 percent of facilities on the Smart Zambia Institute's count that month. Its reach depends on power and a connection, and internet reached 883 health facilities and roughly 1,700 had solar power or solar back-up (2025). Where the patient record does not reach, what the centre gets is aggregate: about 90 percent of health facilities report into the national DHIS2 platform for disease surveillance (2025), counts rather than patient records. Education is thinner: the national education management information system still depends chiefly on periodic school census returns, with monthly digital reporting demonstrated in a single district (2025); equipment for a redesigned system was installed at the education ministry's headquarters and in every province by June 2026, with the redesigned system expected in operation by May 2027.

All ten core back-office systems the GovTech Maturity Index tracks are in place, nine of them in use — financial management, the treasury single account, tax, customs, human resources, payroll, social insurance, electronic procurement and public debt — with public investment management still being implemented (2025). Of the eight whose software type is recorded, six are commercial off-the-shelf products; only the tax system and the public investment system are custom-built.

The financial management system is extensively used at central government level, covering treasury execution and budget preparation, and exchanges data with other systems through dedicated interfaces and the service bus (2025) — central government only, which leaves councils off it. Customs is connected the same two ways, and the civil service runs off-the-shelf human resource and payroll systems, with most HR services online or digitised (2025). The Revenue Authority's Smart Invoice electronic invoicing interfaces with the road transport agency, the company register and the business identification system (2025), and the health record system now accepts a fingerprint checked against the national identity system in place of a physical card, though not everywhere and not as a requirement (2026). Beneficiary verification for the Keeping Girls in School programme has moved from paper forms to a tablet application on which each girl signs for herself. A country analysis found 99% of expected monthly facility reports in DHIS2 in 2024, against 93% in 2019.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The national services portal carried 572 services across 52 providers at 30 September 2026, on the finance minister's account. More than 400 government services — passports, government rent and road tax among them — were onboarded to the state's electronic payment gateway and payable by bank transfer, card, mobile money or cash (July 2026). Sign-in runs through ZamPass, the national authentication and access control service, with companion mobile applications (2026), and the national service portal is rated at transactional maturity, meaning services can be completed through it rather than only read about (2025).

The past two years have added particular transactions rather than a general capability. Road transport services — driving licences, road tax, vehicle registration — have been live on the service bus and ZamPortal since at least September 2024. The Ministry of Labour had 29 services on ZamPortal by April 2025, its own rollout widening from 54 districts to 116. An online passport application and payment system opened in January 2026, with more than a thousand passports processed at that point; a property management system for rentals, valuation and housing services followed in May 2026, built by a local firm and wired to ZamPortal and ZamPay; and a contract tracking system for government contract approvals launched in July 2026. Local government arrived last, Lusaka becoming the first of 116 councils live on ZamPortal in May 2026. Businesses can register, file and pay tax through an online portal, and government buys through an electronic procurement system covering online tendering and contract management (2025).

Five of the seven citizen-facing channels the GovTech Maturity Index tracks are running — the national service portal, the tax portal, the social protection portal, the e-participation platform and the feedback and grievance platform. Two are absent: a government jobs portal and an open data portal (2025).

Zambia ranked 130th of 193 states on the UN e-government index in 2024, scoring 0.5424, with online services the weaker half of that score at 0.4858. The information ministry launched an integrated media reporting system, and a portal for the public service funeral scheme was due to roll out in the first week of October 2026. The meteorological department and the agriculture ministry are building a national digital climate advisory service that sends farmers localised forecast and agronomic advice by text message (2026).

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

Councils became the first sub-national tier on Zambia's Government Services Bus, collecting roughly K21.7 million across eight local authorities in property rates, business levies and permits in the month after the June 2026 rollout (July 2026). That is 8 of 116 councils on the state payment rail, which the Accountant General frames as a revenue-modernisation gain rather than a convenience one (July 2026) — a reading the councils share, with Lusaka describing its own platform's purpose as minimising opportunities for revenue leakage so it can mobilise more own-source resources (August 2026).

The architecture is centralising rather than local. Lusaka's e-Council platform, which lets residents and businesses transact without attending council offices, was introduced through the Ministry of Local Government and Rural Development and integrated onto the national Government Services Bus rather than built as a standalone council portal, and Lusaka was likewise the first council onto the national services portal (May 2026). The revenue system behind it entered a proof-of-concept phase with a first group of councils covering property tax, business and market levies, health permits and fire certificates before extension to the rest (March 2026), alongside a Constituency Development Fund system in data entry across councils intended to track spending transaction by transaction (March 2026).

Network reach is the part that is furthest ahead of use: the government wide area network had been extended to all 116 local authorities (2025), while in Western Province completed council and district office sites were still waiting on last-mile links before the network could be used (February 2025). What the tier below the centre still lacks is the records it would run on. The national financial management system reaches central government and not the levels beneath it (2025); there is no operational national address register, and councils keep disjointed, non-standardised

address records (2023); council valuation rolls are outdated, and paper records, ledgers and receipt books still run through the property tax cycle (2024); and the national registration system has reached only a small minority of districts (2026).

Rural digital data capture

Zambia's rural digital presence is still counted in individual sites: Smart Zambia installed Starlink kits in Moomba Chiefdom in the Kazungula Game Management Area, connecting one rural health clinic and two primary schools to online government services (September 2025). At the point of service, capture remains manual where the systems do not reach: the national patient record had reached more than 2,000 health facilities by July 2026 and runs only where power and an internet connection have been secured, police case books away from headquarters are kept in paper form, and the school system still runs chiefly on periodic census returns rather than facility-level digital reporting. Hardware arriving at a building is not the same as a building capturing data: networking equipment began reaching 40 police stations in early 2026 with no case-recording system established as running on it.

The connectivity underneath is bought rather than earned: ZICTA's Universal Access and Service Fund subsidises towers and last-mile fibre where operators see no return, with installed projects across Copperbelt and North-Western provinces (September 2025) and the programme extending into Muchinga, Northern and Luapula, including ICT provision at Chinsali Special School (June 2026). Power is the harder precondition, with rural electricity access far below the urban rate (2023). Where the network is thin the cost is already fiscal rather than merely inconvenient: poor mobile service in parts of the Copperbelt has cut residents off from social cash transfers and farmer input payments (February 2026), and electronic collection by councils has yet to reach rural districts (July 2026).

The wider rural position it is being built into is deteriorating. Rural Economy is the worst-scoring of the Ibrahim Index's 16 sub-categories for Zambia at 36.7 out of 100, 41st of 54, down 18.4 points over 2014-2023 and the one sub-category the index declines to assign a trend (2023). The two access measures inside it moved the other way, rural market access up 11.8 points to 31.5 and rural land and water access up 12.9 points to 46.1, though market access remains among the country's ten worst-scoring indicators (2023).

Technology

AI

Zambia's own National Artificial Intelligence Strategy describes the country's AI field as fragmented, with no centralised platform for AI data aggregation or model deployment, and the government data exchange incorporating no AI or advanced analytics for data quality, fraud detection or prediction (2024). The same strategy, covering 2024-2026, carries weight well beyond its own subject: policy trackers treat it as the current instrument for cloud services, broadband and digital payments, there being no dedicated policy for any of the three.

What is actually running is narrow and largely at pilot stage. The social cash transfer payment system, which verifies beneficiaries against their national registration card, added AI-based card scanning and biometric matching in a 2025 pilot. UNDP and the Lusaka water utility launched a pilot in October 2026 that brings the utility's production, metering, billing and network data into one platform and uses AI to locate non-revenue water, run on an in-country compute node at the University of Zambia, with the partnership memorandum still to be signed, and the technology ministry is piloting an AI career-guidance platform in technical and vocational training, expected to reach more than 17,000 young people (October 2026). UNDP reports GPU capacity procured, installed and activated with public institutions in Zambia, oriented to inference, its lead use the analysis of critical-minerals data with the mines ministry, for which data access was still to be confirmed (September 2026). A national AI data centre rests on a

memorandum of understanding signed with Huawei and the SMART Zambia Institute in May 2026. The most concrete recent activity has been convening: Lusaka hosted a COMESA and World Bank regional AI workshop in July 2026, opened as a first step toward a regional AI strategy framed against policy fragmentation across the bloc.

ICT Industry

The domestic sector has a listed tier as well as a contracting one: Dot Com Zambia, the fintech behind eToll and eLevy, is quoted on the Lusaka Securities Exchange (May 2026). Government digitisation work itself sits with the SMART Zambia Institute's own e-Government Division and with local ICT firms, with public services consolidated behind a single ZamPortal and ZamPay front end.

Government measures supporting technology startups were recorded as in place in 2025. The wider regulatory setting is one of Zambia's stronger governance results rather than a technology-specific one: business and competition regulation scored 81.0 out of 100 on the Ibrahim Index, sixth of 54 countries and up 9.8 points over the decade to 2023.

Innovation ecosystem

Team Zambia reached the global finals of the 2026 AI for Good Global Summit and Robotics for Good Youth Challenge in Geneva, among nearly 50 participating countries, and has been invited to the 2027 summit (July 2026). The delegation came out of a nine-month identification and mentoring cycle run by E-MARK Innovation Hub, a private hub rather than a state programme. On the standard comparative measure the system still sits low, 112th in WIPO's Global Innovation Index 2025, 90th on innovation inputs and 128th on outputs.

The hub layer is small but active, anchored by BongoHive in Lusaka alongside Ehub Zambia and Jacaranda Hub, all listed in the AfriLabs pan-African directory, with BongoHive running incubation and acceleration programmes including AI-focused cohorts (2025). Inside government there is a public sector innovation strategy with a programme attached, and an established public sector innovation institution whose focus areas are digital skills and public service innovation (2025).

Capital is the thin part. Zambia's startup funding was low in both volume and value in 2024, a year in which one Zambian startup raised a US$400,000 pre-seed round. Public money comes through a Technology Business Development Fund run by the National Technology Business Centre (2026), and the government said in October 2025 that it had finalised an Innovation and Inventors Bill creating a venture capital fund to be run independently of government; no capitalisation figure is published for either. The Ministry of Technology and Science says it will advance the field through a Startup Bill, which has no published text (July 2026). Firms are building in the meantime, and not always along the lines donors expect: the agritech Green Giraffe argues that smallholders already know soil, pests and weather and lack price and demand information, and so signs purchase contracts with farmers before planting rather than pushing advisory content afterwards (July 2026).

Capacity

Literacy

Fewer than one Zambian in five aged ten and over can use a computer: the statistics agency's 2025 national ICT survey found 17.7 percent able to use one, up from 11.8 percent in 2022 and 6.8 percent in 2018, and fewer than one computer user in twenty performing advanced tasks such as programming (2025). The 2022 census recorded internet use at 15% of the population aged five and above. Provision is still being extended to places that have none: ZICTA's Universal Access and Service Fund reached Muchinga, Northern and Luapula provinces in 2026, including ICT provision at Chinsali Special School.

Schooling is answered far more favourably. Zambia sits in Africa's top ten for education and is losing ground on how many children are in school and on what they get once they are there: education is its second best-scoring sub-category in the Ibrahim Index, at 65.2 out of 100 and 8th of 54, one of only two placing in the continental top ten (2023), while Education Enrolment fell 8.8 points over 2014-2023 to 60.3 (10th) and Education Quality 4.0 points to 51.3 (15th). The sub-category still rose 4.8 points over that decade, and Human Resources in Education, at 88.3 and 19th, is among the country's strongest indicators of any kind.

Distribution improved faster than either. Equality in Education — whether educational opportunity is spread evenly across social groups and regions — rose 11.3 points over 2014-2023 to 54.4 out of 100, though that still leaves Zambia 23rd of 54 (2023).

Training and skills

The Smart Zambia Institute launched a decentralised digital-skills training programme for government staff in December 2025, pushing training out of the centre rather than running it from Lusaka. It sits on top of an existing framework: Zambia has both a digital skills strategy and a digital skills programme for public servants, covering basic digital skills and data literacy, with some of the training charged for (2025).

The most visible result of the year came from outside government. The Zambian delegation that reached the global finals of the 2026 AI for Good Robotics for Good Youth Challenge in Geneva, among nearly 50 competing countries, came out of a nine-month identification and mentoring cycle run by E-MARK Innovation Hub — a private hub, not a state programme. Training also runs in a regulatory direction: in July 2026 the Zambia Cyber Security Agency urged journalists to learn the country's cybersecurity laws ahead of the general election, presenting the legislation as protection for media houses against ransomware and disruption.

Tertiary provision is long established: the University of Zambia has taught computing through a dedicated Department of Computing and Informatics since 1998, opening with a postgraduate diploma and admitting its first degree students in 2000. Newer capacity is being built against particular systems rather than in general — SMART Zambia e-government developers took MOSIP training so that the identity platform can be run in-country, though development and capacity building still lean substantially on external partners — and the World Bank's Digital Zambia Acceleration Project carries a digital skills and capabilities component within its 2025-2030 operation. A June 2026 memorandum with Huawei commits to training several thousand young Zambians through the company's global academy.

Research institutions

Zambia's most recent research agreement in this field contracts the work outward: in July 2026 the Zambia Revenue Authority signed a memorandum of understanding, and a non-disclosure agreement, with the International Centre for Tax and Development covering research, capacity building and innovation for data-driven tax administration and domestic resource mobilisation.

Domestic production runs mainly through the universities, where postgraduate computing programmes have been in place since the late 1990s. Funding for anything beyond them is the standing complaint: the chief executive of E-MARK Innovation Hub has called for stronger national investment in AI infrastructure, digital skills and innovation support (July 2026), and the country ranks 112th on WIPO's Global Innovation Index 2025, and 128th on its innovation outputs.

Inclusion

Access to services

Access to Public Services for Women is the lowest-scoring of all 96 indicators the Ibrahim Index measures for Zambia, at 25.2 out of 100 and 40th of 54 African states, despite a rise of 10.3 points over 2014-2023. The index's general measure of whether public services reach all social groups and regions alike sits far higher, at 52.1 out of 100 and 16th of 54, up 12.0 points over the same decade. Both assess how access is distributed rather than counting transactions, and the distance between them is the finding.

Payments are the exception. Financial inclusion reached 80.1 percent in 2025, up from 69.4 percent in 2020, on the Bank of Zambia's FinScope survey, carried by mobile money and running well ahead of the biometric identity enrolment meant to underpin it. Industry accounts put the barrier that remains down to product design rather than access — products built around salaried income in an economy where much of the population earns seasonally (July 2026), though a low-consumption data and voice basket ran at 3.5 percent of GNI per capita in 2022.

Where the network fails the service fails with it: poor mobile coverage in four Copperbelt districts was put to ZICTA in February 2026 as cutting residents off from social cash transfers and farmer input payments. The transfer programme operates in every district (February 2026), but its register reaches only part of the extremely poor population it targets (2022).

Non-citizens are formally provided for, unevenly served. The Bank of Zambia and ZICTA recognised the Refugee Certificate as valid identification for mobile money and SIM registration in 2017, and the World Bank's refugee project enrols them into the national citizens' register rather than a parallel one. In practice, urban refugees without a valid refugee document can be blocked from registering their children's births (2025), and civil registration is thin for everyone: 14 percent of births were registered in 2024, and six percent of the children registered hold a birth certificate (June 2025). The national service portal is transactional rather than informational (2025). The state operator launched a self-care application and a short-code digital financial service in October 2026.

Digital divides

Internet use reached 48.3 percent of urban residents against 13.2 percent of rural residents in the statistics agency's 2025 national ICT survey, in which 29.7 percent of individuals aged ten and over had internet access, up from 25.2 percent in 2022. A compiler's estimate shows the same slow pace: 199,000 internet users added in the year to October 2025, a rise of 2.8 percent that left the penetration rate itself unchanged — growth that keeps pace with the population rather than closing on it, so the share of the country outside the internet altogether is where it was a year earlier.

The sharpest line is rural. The Ibrahim Index scores the rural economy as the worst-performing and by a wide margin the most deteriorated of the sixteen sub-categories it measures for Zambia over 2014-2023 — the only one it declines to assign a trend to at all. Underneath that sits the electricity gap: the 2023 National Energy Access Survey found rural access running at well under half the urban rate, which sets a ceiling on what any connectivity or device programme can reach. The index's own measure of internet use, computer access and affordability has improved far more slowly over the decade than its mobile measure, which is the difference between a phone signal and a usable connection.

Gender and skill are the other two lines. The 2018 measurement put women's internet use below men's, with phone ownership converging; the 2025 survey still separates the sexes by 4.5 points in internet use, 27.7 against 32.2 percent, while smartphone ownership is near parity at 39.2 and 40.7 percent (2025) — device access and use are separating. Place splits devices far more than sex does: smartphone ownership runs at 55.3 percent in towns against 21.0 percent in the countryside (2025).

What is missing is the means to see any of this clearly. Zambia's gender, education, health and food-security statistics score worse for openness in the 2024 Open Data Inventory than its population and price statistics do — the categories a targeting programme would need are the ones hardest to obtain.

Data

National statistics

The rated capacity of Zambia's statistical system rose while the public administration around it fell: Capacity of the Statistical System gained 10.2 points over 2014-2023 to 58.5 out of 100 and 16th of 54, against falls in civil registration, tax and revenue mobilisation and budgetary and financial management — inside a sub-category that went backwards over the same decade.

The gain is in the apparatus rather than in what it counts. Zambia had run a population census within the ten years to 2023 but no agricultural census and no business census within twenty, and across that same decade it fielded three or more agricultural surveys and three or more labour surveys, two household surveys and two health surveys, but no business survey at all. The enterprise economy is enumerated only through a companies register that is not matched to any measure of the business base it covers. The population side is better served: the 2022 census national analytical report was published in August 2025.

The system is weakest where it collects. Data sources is the lowest of the five pillars in the World Bank's Statistical Performance Indicators, in the 20-49% band (2023), against 50-69% for data services and data infrastructure, 70-89% for data products and above 89% for data use. Administrative records do not yet close the gap: the national patient record was deployed in more than 2,000 health facilities by July 2026, while about 90 percent of facilities report into DHIS2 for disease surveillance (2025) in counts rather than patient records, and the education management system still depends chiefly on periodic school census returns, with monthly digital reporting replacing the annual paper cycle in a single district.

Civil registration, the administrative source that could most reduce reliance on surveys, has gone backwards: it is among Zambia's most deteriorated Ibrahim Index indicators over 2014-2023, and birth registration remains one of the lowest rates in Africa. Most of the legacy registration record has been digitised, but a partial account of the population is what is being converted.

Open data

Zambia has no government open data portal, and the measures that depend on one — catalogue coverage and update frequency among them — are recorded as not applicable in consequence (2025), even though a right to information law is in force and rated effective. The right to ask exists; the place to publish does not.

Access to public information is the weakest part of Zambia's Ibrahim Index accountability score and is getting weaker: Disclosure of Public Records stood at 34.6 out of 100, 22nd of 54 and down 2.1 points over 2014-2023, and Accessibility of Public Records at 43.3, 14th of 54 and down 1.7 points. Nothing sits above them to correct it: there is

no data governance body and no data governance strategy for government (2025), while the data protection law and the authority set up to enforce it publish nothing about their work and government does not explain to those required to give biometric data what it is collected for or how it is shared (October 2025).

The pattern repeats: documentation of the systems government runs — financial management, tax and customs, the right-to-information regime, digital skills and public sector innovation — is recorded again and again as existing but unpublished.

What is published, the Open Data Inventory scores low across the board. No category in Zambia's 2024 assessment scores above 6 out of 10: balance of payments, price indexes and population and vital statistics each reach 6, and agriculture 5.5. Five of the 23 categories score zero — money and banking, the digital economy, energy, pollution, and crime and justice, so neither the digital sector nor the justice system publishes open national data about itself. Core economic statistics sit low: international trade 5, national accounts and labour 4 each, government finance 3. Social statistics are weaker still: education and health facilities 4 each, education outcomes, health outcomes, food security and reproductive health 3.5 each, and gender statistics 3: the categories a targeted service-delivery programme would draw on are the least available.

What publication happens is departmental: the Bank of Zambia issues an annual report on the national payment systems, and the finance ministry, the statistics agency and UNICEF launched a national research repository in September 2026, bringing research and evaluations previously held in hard copy or scattered across institutions onto one platform, with no count of holdings or licence terms stated.

Use of satellite data

A national spatial data infrastructure portal, the ZNSDI GeoPortal, is to map rivers, wildlife areas and land boundaries in districts such as Mwinilunga so that artisanal mining licences can be issued against them (July 2026). No national space agency or Earth observation programme had been established as at August 2026.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

Zambia and the United States signed a five-year health financing memorandum on 8 October 2026, which the State Department put at US$2.49bn, US$1.52bn of it from the United States and US$975m from Zambia. The text released that day by the advocacy group Health GAP as the final memorandum leaves out the earlier draft's clause tying the money to a minerals compact and its 25-year specimen-sharing term. In that text the two governments plan a specimen sharing arrangement for pathogens with epidemic potential, within seven days of detection, and a data sharing arrangement on the memorandum's performance, and the United States plans about US$32.2m for the SmartCare Pro patient record over the term, while Zambia commits to connect all 3,216 government health facilities to it by the end of 2030. A Zambian outlet reported a data sharing agreement signed beside the health memorandum, limited to aggregated and de-identified programme data (October 2026).

In April 2025 the US Embassy in Lusaka issued a security alert to its own citizens warning that Zambia's new cyber law required the interception and surveillance of electronic communications in the country. Zambia's Minister of Home Affairs and Internal Security, Jack Mwiimbu, rejected that reading, saying the laws are meant to protect citizens. The target of a national digital ID by the end of 2026 has been argued for domestically as a route off a US blacklist (December 2025).

China activities

Zambia's sovereign AI and cloud programme runs through Huawei (June 2026), the same vendor whose 2015 contract built the country's three government data centres, so what the sovereignty push localises is where the data sits rather than who builds and runs the platform underneath it.

That programme rests on memoranda rather than contracts. SMART Zambia and Huawei signed a sovereign AI memorandum at the 2026 Zambia Mobile Congress covering AI infrastructure, a sovereign cloud, digital public infrastructure for 25 ministries and a co-invested national data centre holding critical data in-country (June 2026), weeks after a separate memorandum with Huawei for a National AI Data Centre (May 2026). Neither has been given a value or a delivery date, and the June memorandum also carries a training commitment through the Huawei Global Academy.

The built stock behind the memoranda is a decade old. Phase I of the Smart Zambia National ICT Development Project, financed by a China Eximbank concessional loan against a Huawei contract, delivered the country's three government data centres — the main national centre in Lusaka with backup facilities at Zamtel's Roma and Kitwe switch offices — along with an ICT talent training centre, from 2016. Phase II financed a Huawei build of communication towers and wireless stations in unserved and underserved areas and was most of the way disbursed by July 2022, while a further Eximbank credit for a Huawei extension of the ZESCO optical fibre backbone had not begun disbursing at that date. Chinese lending also stands behind the ZTE contract to install CCTV across Lusaka's streets, highways and bus stations for the Ministry of Home Affairs.

Chinese policy banks are the largest source of external digital finance to Zambia on record (2025), across four commitments and well ahead of the World Bank and every other financier.

EU activities

No European-built digital infrastructure, no European-supplied government platform and no standing EU bilateral digital agreement were on Zambia's record as at August 2026.

Gulf/UAE activities

No Gulf state or Gulf-based operator had built, financed or supplied digital infrastructure in Zambia, and no Gulf bilateral digital agreement was in force, as at August 2026.

India activities

Senior Zambian officials from the digital sector and line ministries joined a UNDP-hosted learning mission to India on digital public infrastructure, received in Bengaluru on 1 September 2026 alongside delegations from Ethiopia, Malawi, Rwanda, Sierra Leone and the African Union Commission; no agreement or financing was announced from it. Zambia signed a memorandum of understanding in 2023 with the Centre for Digital Public Infrastructure at IIIT-Bangalore to support the design of its digital public infrastructure use cases — help with how the systems are shaped, not money, equipment or a stack the government now runs on. No Indian-financed infrastructure or supplied platform was on Zambia's record as at October 2026.

Digital sovereignty

Zambia launched its national public key infrastructure in September 2026, its master keys held offline and split among several custodians so that no single body controls the country's root of trust, built for ZICTA by South Africa's Altron Security under a contract won three years earlier. The certificates it issues take legal effect under Zambia's electronic transactions law, and Zambia sits in the Africa PKI Forum working towards cross-border recognition.

Beyond the statutory rule that keeps personal data in the country, the state has moved on software. Cabinet directed ministries in June 2026 to adopt open-source technology, launching a national spatial data portal built on open-source software to avoid long-term vendor lock-in, and the Smart Zambia coordinator has said the country kept full national ownership of the 12 million patient records consolidated into its SmartCare Pro platform (August 2026). The government's own hosting is state-owned: INFRATEL, held through the Industrial Development Corporation, owns and operates three Tier III data centres in Lusaka and Kitwe (2024). Whether the state holds the source code and operating skills for the government data centre systems Huawei built, or can exit their support arrangements, was not on record as at September 2026.

The AI layer is being negotiated on stated conditions. At an August 2026 seminar on AI cooperation with China, the Smart Zambia coordinator called for regulatory sovereignty and for cooperation that does not impose a one-size-fits-all approach, and the technology ministry's permanent secretary named limited computing infrastructure as the main barrier to adoption. The terms on which the May and June 2026 memoranda with Huawei for a national AI data centre and a sovereign cloud govern data jurisdiction, portability and exit had not been published as at September 2026.

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